Workers First AI

Ensuring Innovation Benefits People
Report One: Rideshare Drivers and Autonomous Vehicles

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Summary

Our Question: Can Robotaxis Benefit Drivers? How?

Rideshare and taxi drivers built and continue to sustain today's passenger-for-hire market. We start from a clear principle: if robotaxi operations are allowed, they should improve drivers' lives rather than reduce their income or control over their time. This report offers a policy framework designed to make that possible.

We recommend that public officials require robotaxi companies to finance protection against lost driver income and a meaningful additional benefit through initial and continuing payments tied to their service. Before service begins or expands, each company should provide an initial payment, enforceable guarantees, and a reserve. Driver representatives selected under transparent safeguards should decide the additional benefit's form, eligibility rules, and allocation. Public officials should enforce the worker and public requirements, require company records and independent analysis, and reduce or stop service when the requirements are not met.

Whether robotaxi expansion will benefit drivers remains unresolved. Robotaxi companies are expanding in some markets, while workers and public officials have delayed, limited, or stopped proposals in others.[1], [2], [3] Drivers still perform the work, and public officials are still deciding whether robotaxi service may expand and under what terms.

Our Process: Drivers Told Us Their Needs

We built this policy framework with input from about 100 drivers through interviews, a survey, focus groups, and unrecorded conversations. Drivers disagreed about whether robotaxis should operate, but they repeatedly raised four priorities.

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[1] Waymo, "Waymo Raises $16 Billion Investment Round" (February 2, 2026), https://waymo.com/blog/2026/02/waymo-raises-usd16-billion-investment-round/; Baidu, *First Quarter 2026 Results*, https://ir.baidu.com/news-releases/news-release-details/baidu-announces-first-quarter-2026-results/. The company figures are self-reported and not directly comparable.

[2] David Shepardson and Zaheer Kachwala, "New York Governor Hochul Pulls Robotaxi Pilot Expansion Proposal," Reuters, February 19, 2026, https://www.reuters.com/world/us/new-york-governor-hochul-pulls-robotaxi-expansion-proposal-2026-02-19/.

[3] Atlanta: Justin Berger, "Atlanta rideshare drivers rally against Waymo expansion," Atlanta News First (July 9, 2026); Justice for App Workers, "Keep Georgia's Streets Human—Stop Driverless Cars in Atlanta and Beyond." Washington: DC Council Bill 26-0684 and the DC Council Committee on Transportation and the Environment hearing (July 13, 2026).

Drivers wanted to remain able to earn income through driving. They did not want the introduction or expansion of robotaxis to reduce their pay or the amount of paid work available to them. They said that payments and benefits should recognize the work they had already performed and the value they had helped create. They also wanted drivers to help decide who would receive benefits, which choices would be available, and how money reserved for workers would be used.

We estimate that two to two and a half million people earn income from rideshare and taxi driving each year, including roughly 500,000 to 625,000 who drive more than thirty-two hours a week.[4] Because hours alone do not show how much a person relies on driving income, eligibility rules should recognize people who drive as their main work, part-time or intermittently, for a taxi service, or across several apps.

What Research Shows About the Effects on Drivers

Published research does not yet establish how robotaxis are affecting U.S. drivers' earnings, trips, or hours. Our review through August 3, 2026, found no rigorous published U.S. study that isolates those effects. Gridwise reported that trips per hour fell 5.3 percent in AV-active markets in the fourth quarter of 2025, compared with 2.6 percent nationwide, and that hourly gross pay declined in Los Angeles, Phoenix, and San Francisco while rising nationwide.[5] The comparisons provide directional evidence, but they do not isolate robotaxis from other local changes.

A 2026 study of traditional taxis in two Wuhan districts estimated a 10.9 percent short-run decline in daily income after robotaxi service began. That result cannot establish what

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[4] Workers First AI Project, *Research Foundation: The Status and Future of Autonomous Vehicles and Rideshare Driving* (January 2026), unpublished planning document, project archive. The review synthesizes national surveys, city administrative data, and estimates of multi-app work and was revised after feedback from companies, driver and labor organizations, and outside researchers. See also Cody Cook et al., "The Gender Earnings Gap in the Gig Economy: Evidence from over a Million Rideshare Drivers," *Review of Economic Studies* 88, no. 5 (2021): 2210–38; Jonathan V. Hall and Alan B. Krueger, "An Analysis of the Labor Market for Uber's Driver-Partners in the United States," NBER Working Paper 22843 (2016); Ken Jacobs et al., *Gig Passenger and Delivery Driver Pay in Five Metro Areas* (UC Berkeley Labor Center, May 2024); JPMorgan Chase Institute, *The Online Platform Economy in 2018* (September 2018); and Pew Research Center, *The State of Gig Work in 2021* (December 8, 2021). Federal wage statistics undercount the workforce because the Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics program excludes self-employed workers.

[5] Gridwise Analytics, *The 2026 Autonomous Vehicles Impact Report: How Have AV Fleets Disrupted Human Rideshare?* (2026), https://gridwise.io/analytics/autonomous-vehicle-impact-on-traditional-rideshare-report, accessed August 4, 2026.

would happen in a U.S. rideshare market.[6], [7] Because the evidence remains incomplete, we recommend that public officials require company records and independent analysis before robotaxi service begins or expands.

Our Proposal: Five Policy Components for Protecting Drivers

The five policy components below respond to the four priorities drivers raised. We recommend that public officials build any robotaxi program on existing initiatives for fair pay and enforceable rights in human-driven work rather than replace them. Robotaxi-company payments should finance protection against robotaxi-related losses and a meaningful additional benefit shaped by drivers.

Policy Component 1 — Measure How Robotaxis Affect Drivers: Public officials should require company records and independent analysis. Initial protections should begin before analysts can measure robotaxi service's effects. Crossing a published threshold should trigger a response while independent reviewers estimate the group-level effect. Later findings should guide payments and service limits.

Policy Component 2 — Use a Portion of Robotaxi Revenue to Fund Driver Protection and Benefits: Before service begins or expands, each company should make an initial payment and provide guarantees and a reserve. Public accounts should show the money available to drivers and separately identify administration, analysis, enforcement, public payments to the operator, and government contributions to worker benefits.

Policy Component 3 — Limit Expansion and Preserve Work for Drivers: Public officials should set initial limits, preserve enough paid work for human drivers to prevent robotaxi-related income loss without requiring excessive hours, and retain the power to reduce or stop service.

Policy Component 4 — Protect Drivers from Losses and Provide a Driver-Shaped Additional Benefit: Drivers with a documented work history should receive protection

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[6] Zhen Yu et al., "Robotaxis Reduce Taxi Drivers' Income," *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications* 13, art. 629 (2026), https://doi.org/10.1057/s41599-026-07366-x, analyzing 206,949 daily income observations from 1,040 traditional taxis in two Wuhan districts from January through August 2024 with a difference-in-differences design and estimating a 10.9 percent short-run reduction in average daily income after robotaxi introduction.

[7] Workers First AI Project, literature and public-record review through August 3, 2026, documented in *Research Foundation: The Status and Future of Autonomous Vehicles and Rideshare Driving* (January 2026) and the project source archive. The published study identified outside the United States is Zhen Yu et al., "Robotaxis Reduce Taxi Drivers' Income," *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications* 13, art. 629 (2026), https://doi.org/10.1057/s41599-026-07366-x, on traditional taxis in Wuhan, China.

against robotaxi-related losses without having to prove which vehicle caused an individual loss. If service is authorized, companies should also finance a meaningful additional benefit shaped by drivers. Drivers and public officials should decide its form, size, duration, and allocation. Options they could evaluate include cash, support for reducing work hours, voluntary retirement, health coverage, revenue sharing, or ownership.

Policy Component 5 — Set Fair Eligibility Rules and Give Drivers Real Authority: Eligibility should require completed rideshare or taxi work before a specified cutoff and should recognize different forms of work. Driver representatives should decide the required additional benefit's form, eligibility rules, and allocation. Qualified professionals should administer records and payments. Public officials should enforce minimum protections, company duties, service limits, and representation safeguards.

Open Questions

At least three questions remain:

1. **Legal authority:** Can public officials in a particular place enact and enforce these requirements?
2. **Financial feasibility:** Can a robotaxi company meet all worker and public requirements and still operate profitably?
3. **Driver support:** Would affected drivers support the proposed policy for their city or state?

Our model estimates how much several charges on robotaxi service would raise under specified assumptions, but it does not include a company's full operating costs or prove that the complete arrangement can be profitable. Government may separately fund oversight, infrastructure, a defined public service, or worker security for an approved public purpose. Public officials should disclose any public contribution and should not automatically reduce the company's worker contribution because public money is available. Because we have not answered the three questions for any particular city or state, this report does not recommend authorization in any particular place.

Next Steps

We recommend funding locally led efforts in several cities where drivers and their organizations ask for support. Local drivers and their organizations should choose whether to oppose robotaxi service, preserve or strengthen restrictions, or seek enforceable conditions. Where drivers want to test the five components, further work should develop a local policy, support paid and accessible driver review, determine whether government can enact and enforce the requirements, and test whether companies can meet them and still operate profitably.

Insights For Other Sectors

Other industries will involve different technologies, jobs, laws, and remedies. They may still face similar decisions about how workers participate, which businesses bear responsibility, what evidence government requires, and how economic gains are shared. Passenger transportation provides workers, public officials, businesses, funders, researchers, and the broader public with a concrete example because the affected work, companies, trips, revenue, and public decisions can be identified.

Preface — What This Project Is Trying to Make Possible

Public debates about technology too often proceed without the people whose work will change. Experts debate whether jobs will disappear. Companies describe new possibilities. Workers are told to prepare. By the time the evidence is conclusive, companies and public officials may have made decisions about business models, infrastructure, and public policy that are difficult to reverse.

The historical record gives workers reason for pessimism. Economic transitions have repeatedly produced wealth while leaving displaced workers with lower pay and less security.[8], [9] We began this project before the effects of robotaxis were certain because waiting for certainty could leave drivers responding after companies and governments had already set the terms. We believe working people can help shape technological change before companies and public officials make decisions that are difficult to reverse.

We judge technological change by whether it improves working people's income, security, dignity, and control over their time. People drive to pay rent, care for family, study, manage health needs, supplement another job, or build a livelihood over many years. The ability to decide when to work and when to stop can be as important as the income a driver earns. Poor pay and long waits can still turn that flexibility into twelve-hour days.

Technology can remove difficult or dangerous work, extend transportation, and create new services. When a robotaxi completes a trip that otherwise would have gone to a driver, the driver loses the work unless public rules preserve the income or share the gain.

We consider robotaxi service beneficial only if its operation improves drivers' work and lives. For drivers, improvement may mean higher pay for the hours they work, fewer hours without lost income or security, well-paid work for people who want or need it, or other benefits that increase their stability, freedom, and opportunity. Robotaxi service should also provide public benefits that affected communities help define, public officials adopt as requirements, and independent analysts measure.

Passenger transportation provides a practical test of government's ability to respond to economic and technological change. Autonomous vehicles operate on public streets, depend on public rules and infrastructure, and produce activity that can be measured. Drivers have already organized to change the rules of the rideshare industry. Public officials

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[8] Juan Pablo Rud, Michael Simmons, Gerhard Toews, and Fernando Aragón, "Job Displacement Costs of Phasing Out Coal," *Journal of Public Economics* 236 (2024): 105167, https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpubeco.2024.105167.

[9] Louis S. Jacobson, Robert J. LaLonde, and Daniel G. Sullivan, "Earnings Losses of Displaced Workers," *American Economic Review* 83, no. 4 (1993): 685–709. The study reports long-term losses averaging about 25 percent a year for high-tenure displaced workers.

may still be able to act before this transition is complete, although their legal authority differs by place.

We do not know whether any company can meet these terms or whether any city should authorize service. Workers and community members may oppose it, and public officials may delay or refuse it. If officials consider authorization, they should require evidence, financial guarantees, and continuing review.

PART ONE — CAN INNOVATION BENEFIT WORKERS?

Can Robotaxis Benefit Drivers?

Drivers' work helped build the passenger market that autonomous-vehicle companies now hope to serve. Our project asks whether drivers, public officials, riders, and companies can shape robotaxi service so that drivers share in its gains.

For this project, a positive outcome means that robotaxi service improves drivers' work and lives—for example, by increasing pay for the hours they work or providing benefits that increase their stability, freedom, and opportunity. Some drivers may then be able to work fewer hours without losing income, retire securely, or choose other work. Public officials should also require robotaxi service to improve transportation for riders and communities and require companies to meet clear, enforceable obligations before they operate.

Autonomous-vehicle companies have invested heavily and seek new markets. By February 2026, Waymo reported more than 400,000 rides a week across six U.S. metropolitan areas. Baidu reported 3.2 million fully driverless rides during the first quarter of 2026. These company figures use different definitions and cannot be compared directly. They show that geographically limited services can complete hundreds of thousands of rides; they do not establish profitability, public benefit, inevitability elsewhere, or a right to operate.[10]

Worker organizing and public decisions have also changed proposed expansions. New York’s governor withdrew a 2026 commercial robotaxi proposal after opposition from unions and driver organizations. Atlanta drivers rallied and petitioned public officials for limits. The District of Columbia considered a bill that would charge commercial operators and initially limit the number of vehicles each operator could use.

In New York City, Waymo’s supervised testing stopped when its city and state permits expired on March 31, 2026, giving public officials a specific point at which to decide whether testing could continue and under what conditions. Company plans can change, and

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[10] Waymo, “Waymo Raises $16 Billion Investment Round” (February 2, 2026), https://waymo.com/blog/2026/02/waymo-raises-usd16-billion-investment-round/; Baidu, *First Quarter 2026 Results*, https://ir.baidu.com/news-releases/news-release-details/baidu-announces-first-quarter-2026-results/. The company figures are self-reported and not directly comparable.

organized workers can oppose a proposed expansion, preserve a restriction, or seek enforceable conditions.[11], [12], [13], [14]

How Commercial Robotaxi Service Works

This report focuses on robotaxis that perform the full driving task under specified conditions. The people inside ride as passengers. The federal government calls this Level 4 automation. It differs from driver-assistance features that still require an attentive driver and from a vehicle that can operate on every road in every condition. Current services can limit where, when, and under what weather or road conditions a vehicle operates.[15]

The policy framework addresses commercial autonomous vehicles carrying passengers for pay. Personal use does not involve a commercial passenger trip or fleet operator, so self-driving vehicles used only for personal travel require a different policy.

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[11] David Shepardson and Zaheer Kachwala, "New York Governor Hochul Pulls Robotaxi Pilot Expansion Proposal," Reuters, February 19, 2026, https://www.reuters.com/world/us/new-york-governor-hochul-pulls-robotaxi-expansion-proposal-2026-02-19/.

[12] Independent Drivers Guild campaigns page and "IDG Victory in NY: Governor Pulls Robotaxi Proposal from Budget" (February 19, 2026); Independent Drivers Guild petition, "Stop Driverless Cars from Taking Over New York Streets"; Independent Drivers Guild, "About Us," ny.driversguild.org (accessed July 29, 2026). The figure comprises all NYC drivers using the Uber and Lyft apps, who receive basic membership automatically.

[13] Atlanta: Justin Berger, "Atlanta rideshare drivers rally against Waymo expansion," Atlanta News First (July 9, 2026); Justice for App Workers, "Keep Georgia's Streets Human—Stop Driverless Cars in Atlanta and Beyond." Washington: DC Council Bill 26-0684 and the DC Council Committee on Transportation and the Environment hearing (July 13, 2026).

[14] New York City Department of Transportation, "Autonomous Vehicles in New York City," accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.nyc.gov/html/dot/html/motorist/autonomous-vehicles.shtml (listing Waymo's testing permit as active through March 31, 2026); New York City Mayor's Office, "Transcript: Mayor Mamdani Invests $108 Million to Improve Sewer Performance Citywide, Enhancing Neighborhood Resiliency," March 31, 2026, https://www.nyc.gov/mayors-office/news/2026/03/transcript-_mayor-mamdani-invests--108-million-to-improve-sewer-.

[15] National Highway Traffic Safety Administration, "Automated Vehicle Safety," accessed August 3, 2026, https://www.nhtsa.gov/vehicle-safety/automated-vehicle-safety. NHTSA defines Level 4 high automation as a system that performs the driving task within limited service areas while occupants ride as passengers and distinguishes that operation from driver-assistance features and universal Level 5 automation.

The vehicle is only one part of a commercial robotaxi service. The other parts determine who receives revenue, who controls records, what work remains, and which companies could be responsible for public obligations.

Part of the service	What it includes	Why it matters for public policy
1. Vehicle	The car and the equipment it uses to sense and respond to the road.	Ownership, financing, insurance, and vehicle safety may belong to different businesses.
2. Driving system	The hardware, software, maps, and computing that control the vehicle within its operating conditions.	The company supplying the system may control technical records and operating limits.
3. Fleet operation	Financing, charging, cleaning, maintenance, storage, dispatch, passenger assistance, and incident response.	These activities determine much of the remaining work and operating cost.
4. Trip and payment platform	The service that connects riders and vehicles, communicates prices, processes payments, and provides customer support.	The platform may control fares, revenue, trip records, and the relationship with riders.
5. Public systems	Streets, curbs, airports, traffic rules, permits, charging sites, communications, and required data systems.	Public agencies may control access to these resources and may set conditions under applicable law.

Companies may divide these functions among partners, affiliates, and contractors. Any law, permit, or agreement should identify which businesses must provide records, make payments, and guarantee worker benefits. Regulating only the vehicle would miss businesses that control the trips, money, information, or workers.

Before authorizing service, public officials should require companies to meet every applicable safety, accessibility, transportation, privacy, consumer, and worker-protection requirement. They should also identify which changes to the service, its operating conditions, or the responsible businesses will require further review.

Robotaxis may provide some riders with greater independence or availability while removing assistance that other riders need to locate, enter, use, or exit a vehicle safely. The U.S. Department of Transportation created an Inclusive Design Challenge because automated service must address those barriers through specific equipment and operating practices.[16]

[16] U.S. Department of Transportation, "Inclusive Design Challenge," accessed August 3, 2026, https://www.transportation.gov/accessibility/inclusivedesign. The department identifies barriers involving locating and entering an automated-driving-system-dedicated vehicle, securing passengers and mobility equipment, inputting information, interacting with the system in routine and emergency situations, and exiting the vehicle.

Driverless service still relies on people to clean and charge vehicles, maintain equipment, operate depots, support passengers, respond to incidents, and assist vehicles. Those jobs may benefit some current drivers, but their existence does not show that they will match the number, location, schedule, pay, or durability of the driving work the service may replace.[17]

The Drivers Whose Work May Change

Many drivers rely on flexible schedules to manage responsibilities that fixed jobs may not accommodate. People schedule their driving around caregiving, medical needs, school, another job, and other responsibilities. In the Federal Reserve's 2024 household survey, 78 percent of people who performed short-term tasks through an app or website said gig work gave them flexible hours. Only 52 percent said it gave them work-life balance, 61 percent wanted more consistent pay, and 41 percent said they would have trouble making ends meet without the work.[18]

No official national count of rideshare and taxi drivers exists. We estimate that two to two and a half million people earn income from this work in a given year and that roughly 500,000 to 625,000 drive more than thirty-two hours a week. Hours alone do not show reliance: a part-time driver may depend on every dollar because of caregiving, health, another low-wage job, or unstable hours. Public officials should therefore define the

[17] National Highway Traffic Safety Administration, *National AV Safety Forum* (March 10, 2026), https://www.nhtsa.gov/events/av-public-meeting-2026; Waymo, "Partnering with TechForce to Support the Workforce behind Fully Autonomous Ride-Hailing" (February 19, 2026), https://waymo.com/blog/2026/02/partnering-with-techforce/; and Ryan McNamara, Waymo, "Advice, Not Control: The Role of Remote Assistance in Waymo's Operations" (February 17, 2026), https://waymo.com/blog/shorts/advice-not-control-the-role-of-remote-assistance/. NHTSA describes remote assistance as ranging from limited confirmation, information, or permission to manual remote driving and identifies latency, cybersecurity, and human-factors questions.

[18] Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System, *Report on the Economic Well-Being of U.S. Households in 2024*, "Employment and Gig Work," table 6 (May 2025), https://www.federalreserve.gov/consumerscommunities/sheddataviz/gig-work.html. Among people performing short-term tasks through an app or website, 78 percent agreed that gig work let them work flexible hours, 52 percent that it gave them work-life balance, 61 percent that they wished the pay were more consistent, and 41 percent that without it they would have trouble making ends meet.

covered passenger services and workers in a way that recognizes full-time, part-time, intermittent, taxi, and multi-platform work.[19]

Flexible hours can coexist with little practical control over time. Low earnings, unpaid waits, and too few trips may force a driver to remain available for many hours before earning enough to stop. At a 2026 District of Columbia hearing, a security officer described driving for another five or six hours after a nine-hour shift to pay for groceries and her phone bill.[20] A fixed shift maintaining vehicles or working in a depot may help one driver and be impossible for another.

Drivers have already organized to improve this work. In New York, the Independent Drivers Guild helped win in-app tipping and the nation's first minimum-pay standard for app-based drivers.[21] Rideshare platforms, taxi companies, and other responsible businesses remain accountable for adequate pay and enforceable rights in human-driven work whether or not robotaxis operate.

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[19] Workers First AI Project, *Research Foundation: The Status and Future of Autonomous Vehicles and Rideshare Driving* (January 2026), unpublished planning document, project archive. The review synthesizes national surveys, city administrative data, and estimates of multi-app work and was revised after feedback from companies, driver and labor organizations, and outside researchers. See also Cody Cook et al., "The Gender Earnings Gap in the Gig Economy: Evidence from over a Million Rideshare Drivers," *Review of Economic Studies* 88, no. 5 (2021): 2210–38; Jonathan V. Hall and Alan B. Krueger, "An Analysis of the Labor Market for Uber's Driver-Partners in the United States," NBER Working Paper 22843 (2016); Ken Jacobs et al., *Gig Passenger and Delivery Driver Pay in Five Metro Areas* (UC Berkeley Labor Center, May 2024); JPMorgan Chase Institute, *The Online Platform Economy in 2018* (September 2018); and Pew Research Center, *The State of Gig Work in 2021* (December 8, 2021). Federal wage statistics undercount the workforce because the Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics program excludes self-employed workers.

[20] Testimony of Crystal Middleton and Jaime Contreras, SEIU 32BJ, Council of the District of Columbia hearing on Bill 26-0684, reported in "Independence and Protection among Themes at Monday's DC Autonomous-Vehicle Hearing," *WTOP*, July 14, 2026, https://wtop.com/dc/2026/07/independence-and-protection-among-themes-discussed-during-mondays-hearing-on-autonomous-vehicles-in-d-c/.

[21] Independent Drivers Guild campaign records on its 2017 petition to the New York City Taxi and Limousine Commission (more than 11,000 signatures) and its 2018 minimum-pay campaign (a 16,000-driver petition); James A. Parrott and Michael Reich, *An Earnings Standard for New York City's App-Based Drivers* (Center for New York City Affairs and UC Berkeley Center on Wage and Employment Dynamics, July 2018). The TLC granted the tipping petition in April 2017, Uber introduced nationwide in-app tipping that summer, and the TLC adopted the first U.S. minimum-pay standard for app-based drivers in December 2018.

Robotaxis create an additional risk. A minimum-pay standard can protect the rate for work a driver performs; it cannot protect the amount of paid work available if robotaxis reduce it. We therefore recommend that public officials require separate protection against robotaxi-related losses in any program that allows robotaxi service.

Drivers already report lower pay, longer waits, and more hours needed to earn the same income. Platform commissions, expenses, rider demand, the number of drivers, and local economic conditions all affect earnings. A 2025 National Employment Law Project review reported that Uber and Lyft kept about 40 percent of passenger fares on average, compared with fixed commissions of 20 to 25 percent a decade earlier. Robotaxis may add to this hardship, but the report does not assume they caused it or treat current conditions as an acceptable benchmark.[22], [23]

Our review through August 3, 2026, found no rigorous published U.S. study that isolates robotaxis' effects on drivers' earnings, trips, or hours. Gridwise reported weaker trips-per-hour and gross-pay trends in several robotaxi markets than nationwide in late 2025, while Uber reported declines in logged-in time and hourly earnings in San Francisco and Los Angeles. Neither analysis isolated the effects of robotaxis.[24], [25] A separate 2026 study estimated that robotaxis reduced traditional taxi drivers' daily income by 10.9 percent in two Wuhan districts in the short run. That result does not establish what would

[22] Workers First AI Project, driver interviews and focus-group records, San Francisco, Atlanta, and New York City, 2026, unpublished project archive; Justin Berger, "Atlanta Rideshare Drivers Rally against Waymo Expansion," *Atlanta News First*, July 9, 2026, https://www.atlantanewsfirst.com/2026/07/10/atlanta-rideshare-drivers-rally-against-waymo-expansion/.

[23] Dan Ocampo, "Unpacking Uber and Lyft's Predatory 'Take Rates,'" National Employment Law Project, May 19, 2025, updated July 2025, https://www.nelp.org/insights-research/unpacking-uber-and-lyfts-predatory-take-rates/.

[24] Gridwise Analytics, *The 2026 Autonomous Vehicles Impact Report: How Have AV Fleets Disrupted Human Rideshare?* (2026), https://gridwise.io/analytics/autonomous-vehicle-impact-on-traditional-rideshare-report, accessed August 4, 2026.

[25] Uber, *Unlocking the Promise of Autonomy* (May 2026), 10.

happen in a U.S. rideshare market, but it shows that researchers can measure effects across a local market.[26]

Public officials should require the records needed to estimate robotaxi-related changes across groups of drivers and respond when the evidence shows harm. Individual drivers should not have to identify which robotaxi caused a lost trip.

Drivers should be able to choose fewer working hours without losing income or security. Work disappearing and forcing people to drive less is different from giving them the financial freedom to work less. Driving can require long, tiring hours. Some drivers may welcome the chance to reduce those hours, retire with security, or move into different work. Robotaxis can benefit drivers only if drivers and public officials help decide how the gains are used to make those choices possible.

Jobs maintaining vehicles or supporting passengers and voluntary training may benefit some drivers. They do not by themselves show that current drivers can obtain suitable work or regain their income and scheduling flexibility. Research on displaced workers has documented long-lasting earnings losses.[27], [28]

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[26] Zhen Yu et al., “Robotaxis Reduce Taxi Drivers’ Income,” *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications* 13, art. 629 (2026), https://doi.org/10.1057/s41599-026-07366-x, analyzing 206,949 daily income observations from 1,040 traditional taxis in two Wuhan districts from January through August 2024 with a difference-in-differences design and estimating a 10.9 percent short-run reduction in average daily income after robotaxi introduction.

[27] Juan Pablo Rud, Michael Simmons, Gerhard Toews, and Fernando Aragón, “Job Displacement Costs of Phasing Out Coal,” *Journal of Public Economics* 236 (2024): 105167, https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpubeco.2024.105167.

[28] Louis S. Jacobson, Robert J. LaLonde, and Daniel G. Sullivan, “Earnings Losses of Displaced Workers,” *American Economic Review* 83, no. 4 (1993): 685–709. The study reports long-term losses averaging about 25 percent a year for high-tenure displaced workers.

PART TWO — WHAT WE DID AND WHAT WE HEARD

How We Developed the Policy Framework with Driver Input

We asked drivers what would need to happen for them to accept robotaxi expansion. We went to drivers before settling on a policy framework. We then reviewed existing research, invited policy proposals, asked an advisory panel to test the proposals, and combined those inputs with driver testimony and a financial model.

Review of existing research: We reviewed research and forecasts on rideshare driving and robotaxi service. We sent a draft of the research review to companies developing robotaxis, driver and labor organizations, and outside researchers, then revised it in response to their comments. The absence of a published U.S. study isolating robotaxis' effects on driver earnings, trips, or hours led us to make independent measurement the first policy component.

Driver interviews, survey, and focus groups: We interviewed more than 30 drivers across several markets using a common set of questions and received written survey responses from 36 drivers. We also held three recorded two-hour focus groups with about 20 drivers in total in New York City, San Francisco, and Atlanta.

Interviews began with the job, not robotaxis. If a driver did not raise robotaxis, we asked one scripted question near the end. The survey followed the same order. We held the focus groups after receiving policy proposals. Drivers first described what support they would consider fair and what they needed from a policy response, then tested the proposals. Counting each person once, we heard from about 100 drivers, including unrecorded conversations. The participants were not a representative sample of all rideshare and taxi drivers.

Public call for policy proposals: After the initial interviews and survey, we asked researchers, organizers, policy experts, and drivers to address three questions: which public institutions could act, how support could be funded, and what could go wrong. We circulated the call publicly and through professional, industry, and academic networks. Selected authors were paid to revise and develop their proposals.

Advisory panel review: A twelve-member panel of labor leaders, economists, investors, scholars, technology experts, and former public officials reviewed the proposals that moved forward and identified their strengths, weaknesses, and practical risks.

Building the policy framework: Rayan Semery-Palumbo led the synthesis of research, driver testimony, selected proposals, and advisory feedback into the policy framework, with review and input from project co-leads Andy Stern and Tash Diallo. The project also built a financial model showing what several company charges or an auction for limited operating rights could raise and how different distribution rules would change what drivers receive.

What Drivers Told Us

Many drivers across the three cities said they had helped build the passenger market and should not be excluded from its future. Unless another source is identified, the quotations below come from the project's 2026 driver interviews and focus groups.[29]

Drivers say pay has already fallen. A New York driver with more than a decade of experience put it in the math of a single fare: “We were making 78 percent. I got $78 on a $100 ride. Now, a $100 ride, I get $64.” Another said his annual income had fallen sharply even though he worked more hours and found fewer well-paying trips. Asked what autonomous vehicles could mean for her income, another New York driver said, “I have bills to pay, rent and stuff. What am I supposed to do when all this happens and I’m not bringing in the income?” These accounts describe current hardship; they do not isolate how much robotaxis caused.

Drivers disagreed about whether robotaxi service should proceed. A part-time San Francisco driver said, “The enemy is not the technology. I have an Apple Watch, I have an iPhone, I have an electric car. It’s not my enemy.” In a New York City interview, Liakat Ali opposed robots taking over people's jobs. “I don't like it,” he said. “Maybe I am old-fashioned.” Several drivers expected companies to keep pressing forward. Expecting that effort did not mean accepting it.

Drivers want to keep working, not be pushed out. Asad Iqbal said in a New York City interview, “Every person should be allowed to drive that autonomous vehicle, and not to be replaced.” A San Francisco driver and organizer described helping a frail passenger with a cane into his car: “You can’t completely replace what I do.” Another driver said, “You’re going to replace me with the car. Let me fix the car.” Many rejected a payment conditioned on leaving the work because it felt like a payoff to remove them. One New York driver framed the uncertainty as a decision about vehicle debt: “Do I really want to finance a new car, then find out five years from now I ain’t got no job?”

Drivers have earned support, and they know it. “Some of us don’t want free money,” an Atlanta driver said. “Our dignity is being stripped away by them just throwing us away. We just want to know that we’re valued.” A car-service driver tied that claim to the fare: “They take a commission if there is a worker. But there is no worker in a self-driving car.” Among the 36 survey respondents, 18 saw a payment tied to the robotaxi transition as charity or severance, while five read it as recognition of something earned.

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[29] Workers First AI Project, driver interviews and focus-group records, San Francisco, Atlanta, and New York City, 2026, unpublished project archive; Justin Berger, “Atlanta Rideshare Drivers Rally against Waymo Expansion,” *Atlanta News First*, July 9, 2026, https://www.atlantanewsfirst.com/2026/07/10/atlanta-rideshare-drivers-rally-against-waymo-expansion/.

Drivers have heard promises before. A San Francisco driver and organizer spoke about Proposition 22: “They tricked the voters into voting for this. We took them to court and we lost. The only thing we got was the right to union.” Another driver said, “To get what they wanted, they built their own law.” Their lesson was to trust a deal only if its protections were written down and enforced.

Drivers brought policy ideas of their own. Some wanted a licensed person in the vehicle or a human ride to remain available by choice. Others pointed to company-funded driver services, driver ownership of autonomous vehicles, or a continuing share of autonomous revenue. In the survey, 20 of 36 respondents selected driver ownership or a share of autonomous-vehicle revenue as one of the forms of support that would help most; four selected job training and help finding new work.[30], [31]

Drivers know political action matters, and they need allies. “Driverless cars don’t vote,” an Atlanta driver said. “Drivers and their families vote.” Drivers have protested at robotaxi depots, circulated petitions, and appeared before public officials. They also described the difference in reach between organized workers and large platforms. “We can only reach two or three people a day,” one Atlanta driver said. “Uber has a button that reaches a hundred thousand in an hour.” Another driver named the resource workers still possess: “We don’t have gold. We have each other.” Near the end of the Atlanta focus group, one driver told the project: “Just do not give up on us.”

Across the interviews, survey, and focus groups, drivers repeatedly returned to four priorities. They wanted to preserve their ability to earn income through driving. They did not want robotaxis to reduce their pay or the amount of paid work available to them. They wanted payments and benefits to recognize the work they had performed and the value they had helped create. They also wanted drivers to help decide who would receive benefits, which choices would be available, and how money reserved for workers would be used. Driver participation shaped the questions we asked and the standards we used to evaluate policy options. It did not mean every participant endorsed every recommendation.

[30] Colorado S.B. 24-075 (2024), codified at Colo. Rev. Stat. § 8-4-127: the certified driver support organization’s annual budget may not exceed seven cents per transportation task and may be used only to educate drivers and support them regarding deactivations.

[31] Workers First AI Project, *Driver Survey*, 36 responses (2026), unpublished project archive. Respondents could select more than one answer to this question.

PART THREE — THE POLICY FRAMEWORK

How the Five Policy Components Work Together

We recommend two layers of protection in any city or state considering robotaxi service. The first is fair pay and enforceable rights for current human-driven work. The second is the five policy components below, which address the additional risks and possible gains from robotaxi service.

The five policy components depend on one another. Measurement without enforceable limits would document harm after it occurs. A company charge without fair-pay and worker-protection requirements could finance a program while drivers still lose. A legal limit without worker authority could preserve a fixed share of human-driven trips while drivers' pay and working conditions deteriorate. Benefits without fair eligibility rules could divide workers or spread the money too thinly to change anyone's life.

We developed the five policy components from research, driver testimony and driver judgment, submitted proposals, financial modeling, and advisory-panel review. Rayan Semery-Palumbo, the report's author, is responsible for the synthesis and written recommendations. The project co-leads reviewed and contributed to policy development. Participation by drivers, proposal authors, or advisors did not mean endorsement of every recommendation.

This report uses the current contractor structure to test available policy tools. That assumption is not an endorsement of the classification and does not waive classification, bargaining, pay, or benefit claims.

Before service begins or expands, affected drivers should receive a paid, accessible, and multilingual opportunity to review the local policy. Public officials should make the five components, required funding, and financial guarantees enforceable. While service operates, companies should provide records, qualified professionals should administer the program, and independent researchers should measure the adopted worker and public outcomes. Public officials should publish the results and retain the power to require stronger protections, limit service, or end authorization.

Local lawmakers should minimize applications and proof burdens for drivers and give drivers real authority over worker benefits without requiring them to run the program. They should require administrators to use records companies already keep whenever possible.

Policy Component 1 — Measure How Robotaxis Affect Drivers' Work and Lives

Measurement should help public officials protect drivers; it should not delay protection. Initial service limits, secured funding, and protection against loss should take effect before researchers can measure robotaxi service's effects. Later findings should guide changes to company obligations, driver benefits, and service limits. Our review found no published U.S. study that combined robotaxi-operator and rideshare-platform records to estimate the effect on rideshare drivers.[32]

What the drivers said: A San Francisco driver and organizer endorsed an impact study before a company expands its fleet and a rule barring further expansion if the study showed that drivers were worse off. Drivers described reporting as a way to make companies show their work. They wanted public officials to use the results when deciding whether fleets could grow.

What we recommend: Any law, permit, or agreement authorizing robotaxi service should include four requirements:[33]

1. **Robotaxi operators should report their activity:** Each operator should provide the records needed to understand how many vehicles, trips, hours, miles, and fares its service adds to the market. Public reports should show group-level totals without identifying individual riders or drivers.[34]
2. **Rideshare platforms should provide protected driver records:** Independent analysts need secure information on drivers' trips, working time, earnings, and work history. Drivers should be able to inspect records used for benefits. The law should limit collection and prohibit unrelated use of the data.
3. **Independent researchers should estimate the effect on drivers:** Researchers should publish their methods and uncertainty, account for other market changes, and report results for the market and a limited set of driver groups defined with driver input.[35]

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[32] Workers First AI Project, literature and public-record review through August 3, 2026, documented in *Research Foundation: The Status and Future of Autonomous Vehicles and Rideshare Driving* (January 2026) and the project source archive. The published study identified outside the United States is Zhen Yu et al., "Robotaxis Reduce Taxi Drivers' Income," *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications* 13, art. 629 (2026), https://doi.org/10.1057/s41599-026-07366-x, on traditional taxis in Wuhan, China.

[33] Tash Diallo, *Mobility Transition & Resilience Fund*, proposal submitted to the Workers First AI Project, March 2026, unpublished project archive.

[34] Laura Beltran Figueroa, *Autonomous Vehicle Workforce Transition Assessment Act*, proposal submitted to the Workers First AI Project, 2026, unpublished project archive.

[35] Devesh Kodnani and Emily Lemmerman, *Optimal Gradualism: A Managed Transition to Autonomous Vehicles*, proposal submitted to the Workers First AI Project, March 2026, unpublished project archive.

4. **Public officials should respond to evidence of harm and missing data:** Public officials should publish in advance what happens when records are late or unreliable or when income, available work, hours, or income stability cross an adopted threshold. The adopted rules should specify which findings trigger provisional payments, stronger protection, less service, or an end to authorization.

California already collects trip data from autonomous passenger-service companies, while New York City collects trip, availability, fare, and earnings records from large rideshare platforms.[36] Uber has committed to support market-specific research. In a message to drivers, the company predicted "minimal driver impact"; its policy paper reported declines in logged-in time and hourly earnings in two markets.[37], [38] These examples show why public officials should require records and independent analysis from every company whose data the study needs.

Policy Component 2 — Use a Portion of Robotaxi Revenue to Fund Driver Protection and Benefits

Before service begins or expands, public officials should publish a range of possible robotaxi-related driver losses. Affected drivers and their representatives should help decide which losses the program covers and how administrators calculate payments. Company payments, guarantees, and reserves should secure that protection and the additional benefit required under Policy Components 4 and 5. We recommend holding money reserved for drivers in a legally protected fund controlled by government or an independent administrator, not by the robotaxi company.

Public officials should publish a budget showing the company's worker payment, the amount drivers may receive, and the amounts reserved for administration, independent analysis, enforcement, and reserves. They should separately disclose any public payment to the operator and any government contribution to worker benefits. Public officials should

[36] California Public Utilities Commission, Decision 24-11-002 (November 7, 2024), https://docs.cpuc.ca.gov/PublishedDocs/Published/G000/M546/K031/546031802.PDF, and "Quarterly Reporting," accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.cpuc.ca.gov/regulatory-services/licensing/transportation-licensing-and-analysis-branch/autonomous-vehicle-programs/quarterly-reporting; New York City Taxi and Limousine Commission, "Data and Research," accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.nyc.gov/site/tlc/about/data-and-research.page, High-Volume For-Hire Service reporting rules, and driver-pay rules.

[37] Uber, *Unlocking the Promise of Autonomy* (May 2026), 9–10; Axios, "Exclusive: Uber tries a different playbook with robotaxi policy push" (May 8, 2026).

[38] Uber, "Autonomous vehicles are coming to more cities" (May 13, 2026), addressed to drivers; Uber, *Unlocking the Promise of Autonomy* (May 2026), 10.

require companies to make the payments before service begins or expands. Those payments should not replace any other worker or public requirement.

Robotaxi companies' payment obligations should be separate from what rideshare platforms and other responsible businesses owe for current human-driven work. A charge on autonomous service cannot substitute for adequate pay or other enforceable worker rights.

What the drivers said: Drivers pointed to the commission companies take from a human-driven ride, the public streets and curbs robotaxis need, and the spending a neighborhood loses when a worker loses income. “They take a commission if there is a worker,” a car-service driver said. “But there is no worker in a self-driving car.” An Atlanta driver said the public also had a stake.

What we recommend: Any system for collecting robotaxi-company payments should meet five requirements:

1. **Cover the complete robotaxi business:** The obligation should apply to autonomous passenger service, not human-driven trips. If several companies divide the vehicle, driving system, fleet, or platform, the rules should identify who pays and prevent responsibility from disappearing among affiliates or contractors.
2. **Secure the obligation:** Each company should provide an initial payment, continuing payments, a reserve, and a financially capable guarantor when needed. A corporate reorganization should not erase the commitment.
3. **Keep worker money separate and independently administered:** Public accounts should show how much secures loss protection and the additional benefit and separately identify administrative and enforcement costs. Government or an independent administrator—not the company—should control the records and payments.
4. **Enforce payment before service or expansion:** Public officials should compare the money and guarantees with the estimated obligations through the next review. Inadequate funding or nonpayment should prevent expansion and may lead to fines, reduced service, or loss of authorization.
5. **Disclose any public contribution:** Government may separately support research, oversight, infrastructure, a defined transportation service, or worker security for an approved public purpose. Officials should disclose the amount and expected result, compare alternatives, and avoid automatically reducing the company's worker obligation.

Uber calls one danger “regulatory arbitrage”: autonomous operators may favor markets with higher labor costs because replacing human drivers produces greater returns. The company also warns that worker-protection policies should not unintentionally accelerate displacement. Attaching the obligation to autonomous operations rather than human-driven rides follows that principle.[39]

Funding Options to Explore

We recommend that drivers, public officials, and independent financial analysts evaluate three possible funding methods, alone or in combination. This report does not recommend that every community adopt the same method, or that any community adopt one before analyzing its legal and financial consequences:

- **Charges on autonomous trips, miles, or revenue:** These charges can produce recurring funds that grow with service. Each approach requires auditable definitions and company records.[40]
- **Auctions for time-limited operating rights:** An auction can raise money while enforcing a limit on service. If public officials use an auction, the operating rights should expire, remain nontransferable, and create no permanent claim to operate.[41], [42]

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[39] Uber, *Unlocking the Promise of Autonomy* (May 2026), 5–6 and 9–11, especially 11 (describing the risk as "regulatory arbitrage" and warning that worker-protection policies should not unintentionally accelerate displacement); Uber, "Autonomous vehicles are coming to more cities" (May 13, 2026), addressed to drivers; Axios, "Exclusive: Uber tries a different playbook with robotaxi policy push" (May 8, 2026).

[40] Jack Moriarty, *The Driver Permanent Fund: Financing Income Replacement for Passenger Drivers*; Laura Beltran Figueroa, *Autonomous Vehicle Workforce Transition Assessment Act*; Tash Diallo, *Mobility Transition & Resilience Fund*; and Rocky Mountain Employee Ownership Center, *Democratizing Progress: Leveraging Autonomization to Fund Cooperative Membership, Job Retraining, Health Insurance, and Preferential Procurement*. Proposals submitted to the Workers First AI Project, 2026, unpublished project archive.

[41] Kodnani and Lemmerman, *Optimal Gradualism*, proposal submitted to the Workers First AI Project, March 2026, unpublished project archive.

[42] Brian M. Rosenthal, "'They Were Conned': How Reckless Loans Devastated a Generation of Taxi Drivers," *The New York Times*, May 19, 2019; New York City Medallion Relief Program (2021). The investigation documented an inflated medallion bubble, reckless lending, and nearly a thousand medallion-owner bankruptcies.

- **Revenue sharing or a negotiated contribution of company shares:** These options could give workers a claim on long-term growth, but they require careful valuation, governance, distribution, and legal review.[43], [44]

During 2026 negotiations in New York State, Waymo representatives reportedly discussed a roughly $20 million fund for taxi drivers and other displaced workers. Union representatives considered the amount inadequate. The discussion showed that worker support can become part of negotiations over market entry, but it did not answer how much a company should contribute or how drivers should share authority.[45]

Proposed or enacted ride charges in the District of Columbia, Massachusetts, and Illinois show that governments can attach auditable payments to commercial trips or miles.[46], [47], [48] Agreements in longshore work and other industries also show that technology-related

[43] Kate Swain-Smith, *Driver Transition Funds: From Stakeholder to Shareholder* (February 2026), and Jacob Leibenluft, *An Automation Fund for Rideshare Worker Transition* (2026), proposals submitted to the Workers First AI Project, unpublished project archive.

[44] Moriarty, *Driver Permanent Fund*, proposal submitted to the Workers First AI Project, 2026, unpublished project archive.

[45] David McCabe, "Why Waymo's Driverless Taxis Won't Be on Your Streets Anytime Soon," *The New York Times* (June 17, 2026) (reporting that Waymo representatives floated a roughly $20 million fund for taxi drivers and other workers displaced by the technology, and that union representatives called the amount too small).

[46] Council of the District of Columbia, B26-0684, introduced May 1, 2026, §§ 3h–3i; public hearing held July 13, 2026, https://lims.dccouncil.gov/downloads/LIMS/61803/Introduction/B26-0684-Introduction.pdf.

[47] Massachusetts per-ride assessment: Acts of 2016, ch. 187, § 8; Massachusetts Rideshare Data Report; Acts of 2026, ch. 101, §§ 27–28 (repealing the assessment's sunset and its effective-date trigger) (approved June 12, 2026).

[48] Illinois General Assembly, House Bill 5090, 104th General Assembly, enrolled bill, § 11. The bill passed both houses June 1, 2026, and was sent to the governor June 26, 2026, https://ilga.gov/documents/legislation/104/HB/PDF/10400HB5090enr.pdf. The official status page recorded no later action as of August 4, 2026, https://www.ilga.gov/Legislation/BillStatus?DocNum=5090&DocTypeID=HB&GAID=18&LegId=166634&SessionID=114.

revenue can support wages, retirement, health coverage, or other benefits.[49], [50], [51] These precedents do not determine the right design for drivers. We draw three cautions from them: benefits should not depend on a shrinking human industry; training should not substitute for income protection; and narrow eligibility rules should not exclude workers.[52], [53]

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[49] West Coast longshore agreement: Volkswagenwerk Aktiengesellschaft v. Federal Maritime Commission, 390 U.S. 261, 303–05 (1968) (describing the 1960 agreement's $29 million fund, including $5 million a year for five and one-half years, and the employers' expanded freedom to introduce labor-saving methods); U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, *Wage Chronology: Pacific Longshore Industry, 1934–70*, Bulletin No. 1568 (1968), describing the income guarantee for the fully registered workforce and the agreement's retirement protections; International Longshore and Warehouse Union, "The ILWU Story," describing voluntary early retirement and increased wages and benefits under the agreement.

[50] United States Maritime Alliance and International Longshoremen's Association, *2024–2030 Master Contract*, art. XII, §§ 1 and 3 (First and Third Container Royalties of $1 per weight ton and supplemental-wage benefits equal to collections after expenses); Economic Policy Innovation Center, "How the ILA's Demands for Striking Port Workers Stack Up to Other American Workers" (October 3, 2024) (a source critical of the union, estimating annual container-royalty payments of $15,000 to $20,000 per worker under the prior contract).

[51] Music Performance Trust Fund, "75th Anniversary Supplement" and "About," documenting the fund's 1948 creation through an agreement with recording manufacturers and its support for admission-free performances by professional musicians; American Federation of Musicians, "AFM Evolves to Meet Needs of Today's Music Industry," describing the 2017 agreement that added interactive-streaming revenue to the Music Performance Trust Fund; AFL-CIO, "John L. Lewis," describing the UMWA agreement that financed medical and pension benefits in part through a royalty on every ton of coal; 26 U.S.C. §§ 4121 and 9501, imposing a per-ton coal tax and directing the proceeds to the Black Lung Disability Trust Fund.

[52] U.S. Department of Labor, Bureau of Labor Statistics, *Impact of Automation: A Collection of 20 Articles About Technological Change*, Bulletin No. 1287 (1960), 62–64, reproducing the 1959 Armour–meatpacking unions provision: company contributions of 1 cent for each hundredweight shipped, ending when company contributions reached $500,000; authorized uses included training, retraining, transfers, and other efforts to preserve employment, while the fund could not increase severance pay.

[53] Massachusetts Department of Labor Relations, *Certification of Exclusive Bargaining Representative*, TCR-26-12010 (May 22, 2026), certifying the App Drivers Union, SEIU 32BJ/IAM, as the exclusive industry-wide bargaining representative, https://www.mass.gov/doc/certification-of-exclusive-bargaining-representative-tcr-26-12010-certification/download; Massachusetts, *An Act Giving Transportation Network Drivers the Option to Form a Union and Bargain Collectively*, Question 3 (2024); California A.B. 1340, ch. 335 (2025), approved October 3, 2025,

What the Model Says Different Charges Could Raise

The financial model tests a percentage-of-fare charge and an auction for operating rights. Its New York City illustration uses about 240 million app-based trips a year and an average passenger fare near $27.[54]

A charge equal to 5 percent of autonomous passenger fares produces about $32 million a year when robotaxis provide 10 percent of passenger trips. It produces about $97 million at 30 percent, before paying for independent analysis, administration, enforcement, or reserves. Charges of 10 and 20 percent produce about two and four times those amounts. The model also applies annual auction payments of $6,000 and $9,000 per robotaxi, values proposed by Devesh Kodnani and Emily Lemmerman. Applied to the model's assumed fleet size at a 30 percent robotaxi trip share, those values produce about $62 million and $93 million before those costs. They are test values, not recommended bids. The model does not estimate driver losses, show that every required cost would be covered, or establish how much service should be allowed.[55], [56]

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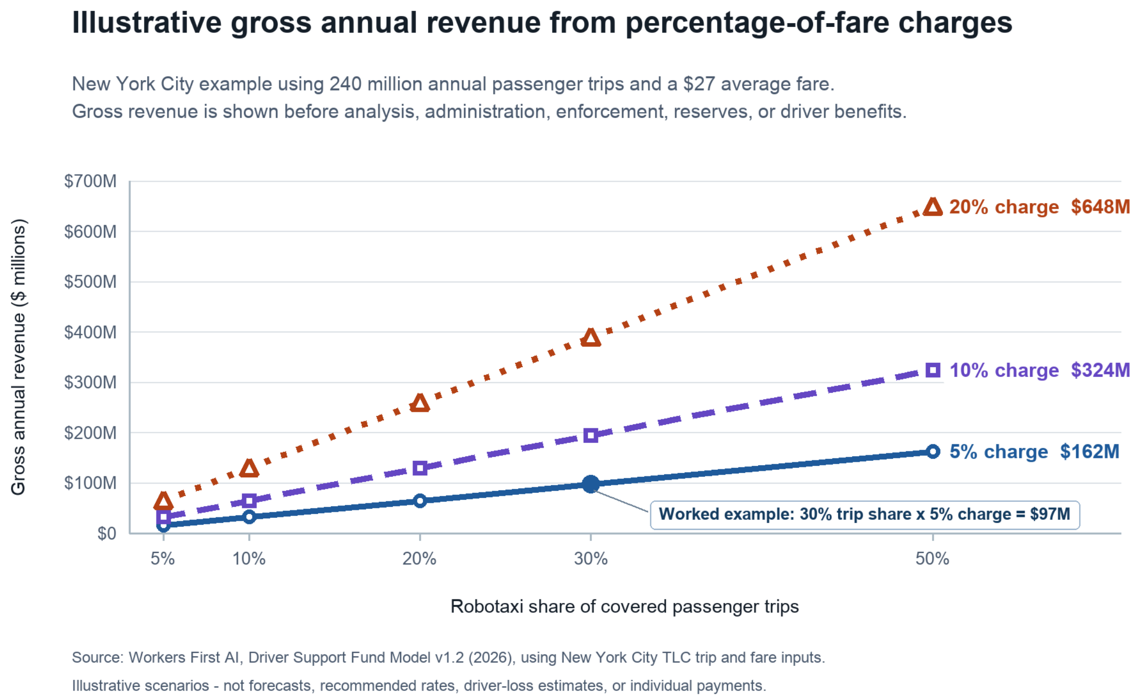
https://leginfo.legislature.ca.gov/faces/billNavClient.xhtml?bill_id=202520260AB1340. Official records checked August 3, 2026; no sectoral agreement was identified.

[54] New York City Taxi and Limousine Commission, *2024 Annual Report* and TLC trip and fare data; Workers First AI Project, *Workers First AI—Driver Support Fund Model*, version 1.2 (2026), unpublished project workbook.

[55] Workers First AI Project, *Workers First AI—Driver Support Fund Model*, version 1.2 (2026), unpublished project workbook. The main text reports gross revenue so that the percentage-charge and auction examples use the same basis. The workbook separately assumes an administrative cost equal to 5 percent of fund revenue; this report does not treat that assumption as a recommended cost or payment rule.

[56] Workers First AI Project, *Workers First AI—Driver Support Fund Model*, version 1.2 (2026), unpublished project workbook. A 30 percent autonomous trip share is modeled as about 10,300 robotaxis, based on roughly 7,000 trips per robotaxi per year. The minimum annual payments of $6,000 and $9,000 come from Kodnani and Lemmerman, *Optimal Gradualism*.



Illustrative gross annual revenue from selected charges at different robotaxi trip shares. The figures are test values, not forecasts or recommended rates; they exclude driver losses, benefits, administration, enforcement, reserves, and company costs.

These figures show only how much the selected charges could raise. They do not show the cost of loss protection, what would remain for an additional benefit, or whether a company could make all required payments and operate profitably. Those questions require local analysis and verified company records.

Policy Component 3 — Limit Expansion and Preserve Work for Drivers

Before considering operating conditions, public officials should decide whether to authorize autonomous passenger service at all. Depending on local law, they may be able to deny authorization, preserve a restriction, require a human operator, or allow limited service under enforceable conditions.

What the drivers said: Drivers repeatedly raised concern about speed and scale. In a New York City interview, Asad Iqbal described the prospect of an overnight transition as frightening. An Atlanta driver proposed a 10 percent limit and asked how much work automation would be allowed to take away. A San Francisco driver and organizer wanted the effect studied before expansion and further growth barred if drivers were worse off.

Where public officials permit limited robotaxi service, the applicable law, permit, or agreement should include four requirements:

1. **Set initial limits that preserve human-driven work:** Limits should cover both vehicles and passenger trips because the same fleet can operate for more hours. They should preserve enough paid work for drivers to avoid robotaxi-related income loss without requiring excessive hours.[57]
2. **Review current evidence before expansion:** Robotaxi companies and rideshare platforms should provide the records required by Policy Component 1. Public officials should publish the independent findings and identify what remains uncertain.
3. **Secure worker protection at the proposed service level:** Before service grows, independent reviewers should confirm that loss protection, the additional benefit, administration, enforcement, and reserves are funded through the next review.
4. **Publish and enforce the response to harm:** Missing data or inadequate funding should bar expansion. If a worker or public outcome crosses an adopted threshold, officials should be able to require stronger protection, reduce or pause service, deny expansion, or end authorization.

The available legal tools differ by place. Where officials cannot limit trips directly, they may be able to limit vehicles, hours, service areas, permits, or access to public infrastructure. Review dates create an opportunity to reconsider limits, not a promise that they will rise. Driver organizations should receive the evidence and participate in the review.

New York City already measures trip shares and has limited new for-hire vehicle licenses after reviewing congestion, driver pay, supply, and service.[58] A 2026 District of Columbia bill would set an initial limit for each autonomous operator and require further review before a larger fleet.[59] These examples do not establish the worker standard in this report, but they show that governments can administer limits, reporting, and staged approval.

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[57] Diallo, *Mobility Transition & Resilience Fund*, proposal submitted to the Workers First AI Project, March 2026, unpublished project archive.

[58] New York City Taxi and Limousine Commission, "Green Rides"; *February 2026 For-Hire Vehicle License Review: Report and Determination*; TLC, "Get a For-Hire Vehicle License."

[59] Council of the District of Columbia, B26-0684, introduced May 1, 2026, §§ 3a-2(a), (d)–(e), https://lims.dccouncil.gov/downloads/LIMS/61803/Introduction/B26-0684-Introduction.pdf.

Policy Component 4 — Protect Drivers from Losses and Provide a Driver-Shaped Additional Benefit

We recommend two distinct forms of support for established drivers. First, every driver who meets the work-history rule in Policy Component 5 should receive protection against measured robotaxi-related losses. Second, if robotaxi service is authorized, companies should finance an additional benefit that improves drivers' lives and recognizes their contribution to the passenger market. The limits in Policy Component 3 should also preserve paid passenger work for human drivers.

Drivers and public officials should decide the additional benefit's form, size, duration, and allocation through a paid and accessible local process. This report identifies options for them to evaluate; it does not choose among those options for any community.

What drivers told us: Several drivers said they wanted to keep working and viewed payments as recognition of what they had earned through years of driving. Others worried that a buyout could become a way to remove drivers from the market. Their accounts support keeping protection against loss separate from a benefit that recognizes past work.[60]

How to Protect Drivers Against Measured Losses

Robotaxi-related harm may appear as fewer trips, lower income after expenses, less predictable income, or more hours needed to earn the same amount. Other local changes may occur at the same time. Drivers should not have to prove that a particular robotaxi caused their individual loss.

We recommend that a local law, permit, or agreement require three steps:

1. **Independent analysts estimate changes across groups of drivers:** Public officials should define the groups and measures before service begins. Analysts should use company records to estimate changes in income after expenses, available paid work, hours, and income stability while accounting for other market changes.
2. **Administrators calculate individual payments from the group estimate and verified work history:** Administrators should calculate payments through a published formula using records from before service or expansion. Drivers should be able to inspect and correct their records and appeal a payment decision.

[60] Workers First AI Project, driver interviews and focus-group records, San Francisco, Atlanta, and New York City, 2026, unpublished project archive; Justin Berger, "Atlanta Rideshare Drivers Rally against Waymo Expansion," *Atlanta News First*, July 9, 2026, https://www.atlantanewsfirst.com/2026/07/10/atlanta-rideshare-drivers-rally-against-waymo-expansion/.

3. **Companies secure protection before the final estimate is available:** Initial payments, guarantees, and reserves should reflect a published range of possible losses. The law, permit, or agreement should identify when preliminary evidence of serious harm triggers provisional payments or stronger service limits. Later payments should correct any shortfall.

Why Require an Additional Benefit

Loss protection addresses harm. If robotaxi service is allowed, companies should finance an additional benefit through which drivers receive part of the value created by autonomous service. Rideshare and taxi drivers built and continue to sustain the passenger market. Uber says its autonomous business uses road footage from regular vehicles, maps informed by billions of trips, and information from complex pickup sites.[61]

The broader aim is to share gains before they accrue primarily to companies and investors. Driver representatives should help decide the purpose and allocation of the additional benefit, informed by financial and legal analysis.[62], [63]

The requirement is a meaningful additional benefit. Drivers and public officials should evaluate options that include:

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[61] Uber, "Driving Autonomous Forward" (accessed July 30, 2026), describing road footage from data-collection fleets and dashcam networks, mapping informed by billions of trips, and data developed from trips at airports, stadiums, and other complex venues; Uber, "Road Data Collection Privacy Hub" (accessed July 30, 2026), explaining that outward-facing cameras are mounted on regular vehicles driven and owned by third-party operators and that footage is shared with selected autonomous-driving partners to train and validate their systems; Uber, "Uber AV Labs: Where Autonomy Meets Reality" (accessed July 30, 2026), describing the use of real-world driving data and rare road scenarios in training and evaluation pipelines.

[62] Rayan Semery-Palumbo, *Recovering Wages and Wealth: What We Deserve in the Age of AI* (Economic Security Project, May 5, 2026), https://economicsecurityproject.org/resource/recovering-wages-and-wealth/. The citation supports the conceptual distinction between cash as recognition of contribution and cash as charity. The project's fieldwork records, not this essay, supply the report's interview and survey findings.

[63] Rayan Semery-Palumbo, "Approaching Structural Equality: Reshaping American Meritocracy towards Greater Fairness for Essential Workers" (DPhil thesis, University of Oxford, 2025), https://doi.org/10.5287/ora-vmn0dongp. The thesis supports the narrow argument that taking contribution, reward, and opportunity seriously can support greater fairness for essential workers; it does not establish that this report's specific benefit or governance design will work.

- **Direct cash or support for working fewer hours:** Predictable, unrestricted payments could help drivers replace income, care for family, or reduce long hours.[64], [65]
- **A voluntary retirement benefit:** Secure income and health support could help long-serving drivers leave or reduce work by choice.
- **Health coverage or shared driver services:** Possible uses include health and safety benefits, driver centers, legal help, financial counseling, and assistance challenging removal from an app.[66], [67]

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[64] Moriarty, *Driver Permanent Fund*; Alaska Permanent Fund Dividend Division, "Historical Timeline," accessed August 3, 2026, https://pfd.alaska.gov/division-info/historical-timeline.

[65] Economic Security Project, *The Guaranteed Income Blueprint* (March 14, 2024), https://economicsecurityproject.org/resource/gi-blueprint/; KyungSun Lee and Madeline Neighly, *The Power of Cash: How Guaranteed Income Can Strengthen Worker Power* (Economic Security Project, May 1, 2023), https://economicsecurityproject.org/resource/the-power-of-cash/. These sources inform the general principles that cash can be direct, predictable, accessible, and usable according to recipients' needs. They do not constitute Economic Security Project endorsement of this report's autonomous-vehicle proposal.

[66] Colorado S.B. 24-075 (2024), codified at Colo. Rev. Stat. § 8-4-127: the certified Driver Support Organization's state-approved annual budget may not exceed seven cents per transportation task, and each transportation network company must remit its quarterly share; Colorado Department of Labor and Employment, "Transportation Network Company" and INFO no. 23B, accessed August 4, 2026, https://cdle.colorado.gov/dlss/labor-laws-by-topic/transportation-network-company-tnc, describing the organization's driver-education and deactivation-support roles.

[67] The Black Car Fund, "History" and "F.A.Q.s": created by New York statute in 1999 to provide workers' compensation and other benefits to eligible for-hire drivers.

- **Revenue sharing, ownership, or voluntary training:** Drivers proposed claims on autonomous revenue, vehicle ownership, company shares, and support for suitable new jobs. These ideas require further legal, financial, and operational analysis.[68], [69], [70], [71], [72]

If a program offers individual options, each recipient should choose among them. Public officials and administrators should make each promised benefit simple to use and ensure that companies have funded it securely.

One Option to Explore: Voluntary Retirement or Reduced Hours

A voluntary benefit could allow long-serving drivers to stop working with income and health security or reduce long hours without leaving driving entirely. Driver deliberation, financial analysis, and legal review would still need to determine who qualifies, what the benefit provides, how long it lasts, and how it interacts with taxes and public benefits.[73]

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[68] Rocky Mountain Employee Ownership Center, *Democratizing Progress*, and Lynch, *Driving Ownership*, proposals submitted to the Workers First AI Project, 2026, unpublished project archive.

[69] Predistribution Initiative, *Driver Equity Transition Stakes: Turning Autonomous Vehicle Displacement into Broad-Based Ownership*, proposal submitted to the Workers First AI Project, March 4, 2026, unpublished project archive.

[70] Graeme Nuttall and the Institute for the Future of Work, *Using Driver Ownership Trusts to Ensure Workers Benefit in the Autonomous Vehicles Sector*, proposal submitted to the Workers First AI Project, 2026, unpublished project archive.

[71] Renan Magalhães, *Collective Ownership as a Condition of Autonomous Mobility: A Driver Equity & Cooperative Transition*, proposal submitted to the Workers First AI Project, 2026, unpublished project archive.

[72] Ariana R. Levinson, *Driver Ownership of Passenger Transportation Companies*, proposal submitted to the Workers First AI Project, 2026, unpublished project archive; Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System, "Greater Wealth, Greater Uncertainty: Changes in Racial Inequality in the Survey of Consumer Finances" (October 18, 2023), using the 2022 Survey of Consumer Finances.

[73] Social Security Administration, "Your Retirement Age and When You Stop Working," accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.ssa.gov/benefits/retirement/planner/stopwork.html; Medicare.gov, "When Does Medicare Coverage Start?," accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.medicare.gov/basics/get-started-with-medicare/sign-up/when-does-medicare-coverage-start. Social Security benefits depend on earnings history and claiming age and may begin as early as age 62 at a reduced amount; Medicare's initial enrollment period generally begins around age 65.

If drivers and public officials explore retirement or reduced-hours benefits, they should require three safeguards. Participation should be voluntary; loss protection should never depend on leaving work. Drivers should receive clear information about income, health coverage, taxes, and public benefits. Companies should provide enforceable guarantees for every benefit already awarded.

Public officials should not allow more robotaxi service merely because some drivers choose retirement or reduced-hours benefits. Those choices should not reduce the paid work reserved for other human drivers.

When New Jobs Count as Worker Protection

Autonomous fleets still require workers for maintenance, charging, cleaning, dispatch, customer support, incident response, engineering, and remote assistance. Some positions may offer stable, well-paid work, but their existence alone does not provide a transition for current drivers. Available company figures do not show that new fleet jobs will replace passenger drivers one for one.[74]

Public officials should count new jobs as worker protection only when an enforceable agreement identifies the jobs' wages, benefits, schedules, and locations; gives current drivers real access; and reports training, placement, and retention. Training should remain voluntary, and ordinary wages for new work should not reduce the company's loss-protection or additional-benefit obligations.

Policy Component 5 — Set Fair Eligibility Rules and Give Drivers Real Authority

We recommend that local lawmakers define an established group of drivers based on rideshare or taxi work completed before a specified cutoff date. Local lawmakers should recognize full-time, part-time, intermittent, taxi, and multi-platform work and rely on records drivers can inspect and correct. Creating a new driver account should not by itself establish eligibility.

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[74] Waymo, "Partnering with TechForce to Support the Workforce behind Fully Autonomous Ride-Hailing," February 19, 2026, https://waymo.com/blog/2026/02/partnering-with-techforce/, announcing that it would fund 28 scholarships and describing "thousands of roles" across partner organizations; Ryan McNamara, Waymo, "Advice, Not Control: The Role of Remote Assistance in Waymo's Operations," February 17, 2026, https://waymo.com/blog/shorts/advice-not-control-the-role-of-remote-assistance/, explaining that remote-assistance agents do not continuously monitor or drive individual vehicles and reporting about 70 agents on duty worldwide at a given time for a 3,000-vehicle fleet.

Who Should Qualify for Loss Protection and the Additional Benefit

Every driver in the established group should receive the loss protection described in Policy Component 4 when independent analysis finds a robotaxi-related loss for that driver's group. Participation should not waive any right governing human-driven work.

Driver representatives should decide how to allocate the required additional benefit. They should evaluate whether it reaches the whole established group, provides more to drivers with longer service or greater reliance on driving income, or combines those approaches. Possible measures include years active, completed trips or hours, multi-platform work, and the share of income earned from driving. The rules should remain simple enough to deliver benefits quickly and avoid subjective judgments of personal worth.[75], [76], [77]

Loss protection should come first. The required additional benefit should be large enough to achieve its stated purpose for the people who receive it. If the available terms cannot secure loss protection and a meaningful additional benefit, public officials should seek more company funding, preserve more human-driven work, allow less robotaxi service, or refuse authorization.

People who begin driving after the cutoff should retain every right governing human-driven work. Any future robotaxi-related benefit for later work would require a separate public decision.

Who Decides and Who Administers

We recommend that local lawmakers give drivers authority over benefit decisions without requiring them to administer the program:

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[75] Workers First AI Project, advisory panel review records, May 15–June 1, 2026, unpublished project archive. The report does not attribute this position to an individual advisor without separate permission.

[76] Rayan Semery-Palumbo, *Recovering Wages and Wealth: What We Deserve in the Age of AI* (Economic Security Project, May 5, 2026), https://economicsecurityproject.org/resource/recovering-wages-and-wealth/. The citation supports the conceptual distinction between cash as recognition of contribution and cash as charity. The project's fieldwork records, not this essay, supply the report's interview and survey findings.

[77] Rayan Semery-Palumbo, "Approaching Structural Equality: Reshaping American Meritocracy towards Greater Fairness for Essential Workers" (DPhil thesis, University of Oxford, 2025), https://doi.org/10.5287/ora-vmn0dongp. The thesis supports the narrow argument that taking contribution, reward, and opportunity seriously can support greater fairness for essential workers; it does not establish that this report's specific benefit or governance design will work.

1. **Driver representatives:** Within the legal safeguards, they should decide the form of the required additional benefit, its eligibility rules, and the allocation of money reserved for it. They should not be permitted to waive loss protection, rights governing human-driven work, company data duties, or service limits.
2. **Individual eligible drivers:** If the program offers a menu of individual benefits, each recipient should choose among those options. Every eligible driver should be able to inspect and correct their records and appeal an eligibility or payment decision to an independent body.
3. **Qualified administrators:** Paid professionals should verify records, issue notices, calculate and deliver payments, protect data, manage reserves, and handle routine claims. Drivers should not have to perform this work.
4. **Public officials:** They should establish and enforce the minimum protections, company duties, service limits, data requirements, and representative safeguards. They should decide whether robotaxi service may begin, expand, continue, or end and retain every duty the law does not allow them to delegate.

Existing unions and worker organizations retain their legal and bargaining rights. A local process may use an existing elected or certified organization, create a representative body, or combine structures. Local lawmakers should determine the representative structure.

Any representative process should include transparent selection or ratification, language access, conflict rules, public accounting, and independent appeals. Public officials should retain responsibility for enforcing the law and minimum protections. If they reject a decision by driver representatives, they should explain why publicly.

Public reports should show the money secured for loss protection and the additional benefit, how many drivers received support, whether payments arrived on time, and whether appeals corrected errors. Money reserved for the broader eligible workforce should not be diverted for private advantage or limited to one organization's members.

Two Questions to Answer Before Robotaxi Service Begins

The five policy components state how public officials should protect drivers. Before authorizing service, public officials should also identify the transportation benefit they expect the service to deliver and determine whether the complete worker and public requirements can be financed.

What Public Benefits Should Robotaxi Service Deliver?

Robotaxi service may improve independence, privacy, or transportation access for some riders while removing assistance that others rely on. Public officials should define the benefit a company claims, the harms they will monitor, and the evidence required to continue or expand service.

Disability advocates illustrate why those questions cannot be answered in the abstract. Some blind and low-vision riders see autonomous vehicles as another option when transit or paratransit is unavailable or drivers deny service involving guide dogs. Other advocates warn about wheelchair inaccessibility, smartphone-only booking, unresolved wheelchair securement, and the loss of human assistance.[78] Affected riders and community organizations should help define and evaluate any accessibility requirements.

Government may decide to fund infrastructure or purchase a defined transportation service if independent evidence shows a public benefit. Officials should compare robotaxis with other ways to meet the same need, including transit, paratransit, and accessible taxi service, and disclose any public spending separately. Public officials should allow service to expand only while companies meet the adopted worker and public requirements.

Can a Company Meet Every Worker and Public Requirement and Still Operate Profitably?

The project's financial model estimates the gross revenue that selected charges or auctions could raise. It does not estimate driver losses, the full cost of benefits and administration, or a robotaxi company's operating and capital costs. Public information also does not provide those answers. The report therefore cannot establish whether a company can meet all worker and public requirements, operate profitably, and maintain current fares.

One peer-reviewed model found that robotaxis could cost less than conventional taxis under some assumptions, but its results changed substantially with vehicle use, annual mileage, technology costs, and staffing. It did not measure current company costs or include the obligations in this report.[79] Before authorization, an independent reviewer should use verified information to determine whether a company can meet every obligation at a realistic service level and fare.[80]

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[78] American Council of the Blind, "Accessing Autonomous Vehicles" (June 2, 2025; updated March 23, 2026); Consortium for Constituents with Disabilities Transportation Task Force, comments to the U.S. Department of Transportation, DOT-OST-2024-0049 (August 1, 2024); U.S. Department of Transportation, "Inclusive Design Challenge," accessed August 3, 2026, https://www.transportation.gov/accessibility/inclusivedesign.

[79] Leah Kaplan, Lola Nurullaeva, and John Paul Helveston, "Modeling the Operational and Labor Costs of Autonomous Robotaxi Services," *Transport Policy* 159 (2024): 108–19, https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tranpol.2024.10.010. The study models robotaxi costs using observations, expert interviews, archival data, and sensitivity analysis. It estimates 57 to 76 percent fewer frontline jobs in its modeled shift from conventional taxis to robotaxis, while identifying vehicle use, annual mileage, technology costs, and labor ratios as important uncertainties. It does not report Waymo's current costs or include the worker package proposed in this report.

[80] Waymo, "Waymo Raises $16 Billion Investment Round" (February 2, 2026), https://waymo.com/blog/2026/02/waymo-raises-usd16-billion-investment-round/;

The company should remain responsible for the obligations attached to permission to operate robotaxis for profit. Government may separately fund oversight, infrastructure, a defined public service, or additional worker security for an approved public purpose, but it should disclose the spending and compare alternatives. If the complete terms cannot be financed without weakening worker protection or shifting company obligations to the public, officials should require different terms, allow less service, or refuse authorization.

Local Decisions This Report Cannot Make

Before commercial robotaxi service begins or expands, drivers and public officials must still answer five local questions:

1. **Which drivers qualify?** What completed work establishes eligibility, and which businesses remain responsible for fair pay and enforceable rights in human-driven work?
2. **How much robotaxi service will public officials allow?** What initial limits preserve paid work, and which findings trigger stronger protection, less service, or an end to service?
3. **What will robotaxi companies fund?** What loss protection and required additional benefit can they secure, which drivers qualify, and how will multiple operators share responsibility?
4. **Who holds each responsibility?** How will drivers choose representatives? Who will protect records, administer benefits, hear appeals, and enforce violations?
5. **What must the public receive?** Which transportation benefits must companies deliver, and when would separate public spending be justified?

Driver representatives should control the required additional benefit's form, eligibility rules, and allocation within the legal safeguards and participate in the other decisions.

An Additional Question: Should Platforms Limit New Driver Sign-Ups?

This report does not recommend limiting new driver sign-ups now. It recommends that drivers and public officials evaluate possible limits only if evidence shows that platforms are adding more drivers than the available work can support. If they pursue that option,

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Alphabet Inc., *2025 Form 10-K* (February 5, 2026), https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/1652044/000165204426000018/goog-20251231.htm, reporting Other Bets as a combined segment rather than disclosing Waymo's full standalone operating economics; Uber Technologies, Inc., *Fourth Quarter 2025 Prepared Remarks* (February 4, 2026), https://s23.q4cdn.com/407969754/files/doc_earnings/2025/q4/transcript/Uber-Q4-25-Prepared-Remarks.pdf, identifying regulation, hardware cost, local operations, utilization, and demand as major commercial variables for autonomous service.

they should protect adequate pay and access to flexible work, prevent discrimination, and avoid giving platforms control over scarce work.

PART FOUR — WHAT COMES NEXT

What Further Investment Should Accomplish

We recommend using the next round of funding to help workers in several cities pursue goals they choose, test which protections public officials can enact and enforce, and determine what companies can finance. The funded projects should also create legal, financial, research, and communications tools that other communities can adapt.

Driver-Led Local Campaigns

Affected drivers and their organizations should decide whether to invite outside support and what goal it serves. Local workers should control the public voice. Outside partners can provide organizing, legal, financial, research, coalition, and communications support while drivers remain involved through implementation and enforcement.

Atlanta drivers asked this project for advocacy support and its findings; they did not commission a campaign. Any further campaign work in Atlanta should begin only after a new local invitation and agreement. Because Georgia law limits what Atlanta can regulate directly, support may begin with organizing, coalition and media work, evidence collection, and city and state outreach while local counsel identifies the available public actions.[81], [82]

Shared Tools for Local Campaigns

Local worker organizations should not have to recreate the same work in each city. Shared legal, financial, data, and communications support can produce reusable analyses, models, policy terms, and public explanations. Local campaigns can then adapt those tools to their law, market, workforce, and goals.

One Possible Local Strategy: Limited Robotaxi Service

Some drivers may choose to explore limited robotaxi service under enforceable worker and public requirements. Others may seek to preserve restrictions or prevent service. Outside partners should follow the goal chosen by local workers. Any limited authorization should remain reversible, create no right to expand, and end if the adopted requirements are not

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[81] Berger, "Atlanta Rideshare Drivers Rally"; Workers First AI Project, Atlanta focus-group and follow-up records, 2026, unpublished project archive; O.C.G.A. §§ 40-1-1 and 40-8-11; Workers First AI Project, *Research Foundation*, § 5.1. Atlanta drivers asked the project for advocacy support and the project's results; they did not commission a next phase.

[82] Berger, "Atlanta Rideshare Drivers Rally"; Justice for App Workers, "Keep Georgia's Streets Human—Stop Driverless Cars in Atlanta and Beyond"; Workers First AI Project, *Research Foundation*, § 5.1, "State Preemption of Local Authority" and "City Authority: Infrastructure, Operations, and Indirect Leverage"; O.C.G.A. §§ 40-1-1 and 40-8-11.

met. Success means that local workers strengthen their power and win the outcome they choose; it does not require robotaxi deployment.

Workers in Other Industries Are Already Shaping Automation

Truck, parcel, and transit workers have already used legislation and bargaining to shape automation. Teamsters have advanced human-operator bills and bargained for notice and a voice over technology's effects. The Transport Workers Union says its 2024 agreement with the Central Ohio Transit Authority requires union approval before autonomous vehicles enter service and bars layoffs or wage cuts caused by new technology.[83]

Different institutions provide different tools: cities can set conditions on permits and streets, states can regulate vehicles, public agencies can set purchasing terms, and unions can bargain over introduction, job security, and benefits. Each occupation will require different evidence and solutions.

This project studied rideshare and taxi drivers, not workers in freight, delivery, transit, or care. Passenger driving is a useful first case because the technology is visible, government decisions can be identified, and commercial trips can be measured. The five components are not ready-made solutions for other industries. Workers in those industries can use the same kinds of questions—about evidence, responsibility, limits, benefits, and worker authority—to develop approaches suited to their work and laws.

A Longer-Term Research Question: Who Shares in Automation's Gains?

For commercial robotaxis, public officials can attach a worker obligation to measurable trips and permission to operate. Many automated systems do not involve an equally visible transaction or depend on a local government decision. That raises a longer-term question: when automation produces economic gains, how should workers and the public share in them?

One idea worth further research is a public Automation Fund, separate from the driver framework. It could receive money or assets tied to automation gains and use the returns

[83] International Brotherhood of Teamsters, *National Master United Parcel Service Agreement*, August 1, 2023–July 31, 2028, art. 6, § 4 (requiring six months' notice and bargaining over the effects before specified technologies, including driverless vehicles, may be implemented); International Brotherhood of Teamsters, "Teamsters-Backed Autonomous Vehicle Human Operator Bill Heads to Newsom" (August 30, 2024), and "Teamsters Call on Colorado Gov. Jared Polis to Sign HB 25-1122" (May 7, 2025); Transport Workers Union, "Stopping AVs from Replacing Bus Operators, Mechanics and Other Transit Workers" (February 23, 2024) (describing the TWU Local 208–COTA agreement). The full COTA agreement is not public; the report attributes its terms to TWU.

for worker benefits, public services, dividends, or a combination. Alaska's Permanent Fund offers an analogy, not a design; an Automation Fund would require its own revenue source, legal authority, governance, and distribution rules.[84]

Researchers, funders, worker organizations, and public officials can pursue that national question separately without delaying action for drivers. When public officials can identify an economic gain and the workers whose labor helped make it possible, those workers should help decide how a meaningful share is secured and used.

[84] Alaska Permanent Fund Corporation, “History” and “Performance,” accessed July 27, 2026, https://apfc.org/.

CONCLUSION

Workers have already changed the rules of the rideshare industry. They organized for pay, benefits, bargaining, fair treatment, and institutions that did not exist when the platforms arrived. Robotaxis present a different test: pay and rights protections for human-driven work remain essential, but those protections alone cannot protect drivers if autonomous service reduces the amount of paid work available.

Many drivers spend long days waiting for enough trips to cover rent, bills, and family needs. A technology that lets people choose to work fewer hours without losing income, security, or useful service could improve their lives. A technology that removes paid trips and transfers income away from drivers would make their lives worse.

We recommend that public officials combine company-funded protection against loss, a meaningful additional benefit shaped by drivers, and limits on robotaxi service in any local policy that allows service. Independent evidence should guide later changes, and public officials should retain the power to reduce or stop service.

Organizing and enforceable public action made possible the pay standards, fleet limits, support organizations, and bargaining rights cited here. Recent proposals contain some elements, but our review through August 5, 2026, found none that combines all five policy components.[85] The drivers' lesson from Proposition 22 remains: a protection not written down and enforced is not a protection.

[85] Workers First AI Project, legislation and public-record review through August 5, 2026. The review included D.C. B26-0684, Boston Docket 1432, Minnesota H.F. 4216, and New York A.11500; see the bibliography for official links. The proposals address different combinations of authorization, operating limits, study, fees, workforce programs, or public requirements. The review did not identify one that combined all five components described in this report.

The history of elevator operators shows why attrition is insufficient. Their union called jobs that disappeared when departing workers were not replaced "silent firings."[86], [87] Retirement can be a genuine benefit when chosen; it cannot become the rule for allowing an occupation to disappear. The larger aim is to protect current workers, share value, preserve good work, and establish fair rights for those who come next.

Other industries will require different rules, but the underlying responsibilities remain. People affected by change should have real power in deciding how their work and lives improve. Businesses profiting under public authorization should help finance worker protection and broadly shared gains. Government should require evidence and change course when companies fail to meet their obligations.

Public officials may authorize limited service under enforceable conditions, preserve a restriction, or refuse service. If a city or state requires companies participating in robotaxi service to protect drivers and share enough of the gains to improve their lives, the country can demonstrate a larger promise: technological progress should improve the lives of the people whose work made it possible.

The jobs are still here. The choices are still open. Elevator operators watched their occupation disappear. Here, drivers have helped define what a fair response must achieve while they can still shape what comes next. If we can meet that challenge here, we can demonstrate we are committed to becoming a country where technological progress gives working people more security, freedom, and time. We can show we are committed to becoming whole.

[86] James E. Bessen, "How Computer Automation Affects Occupations: Technology, Jobs, and Skills," Boston University School of Law, Law and Economics Research Paper no. 15-49 (2016), 5, https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.2690435. Bessen finds that elevator operator was the only detailed occupation in the 1950 Census whose subsequent decline and disappearance could be attributed largely to automation.

[87] Building Service Employees' International Union, statement prepared for the National Commission on Technology, Automation, and Economic Progress, in *Statements Relating to the Impact of Technological Change*, appendix vol. 6 of *Technology and the American Economy* (February 1966), 57. The union cites U.S. Census Bureau counts of 76,860 elevator operators in 1940, 89,185 in 1950, and 71,882 in 1960 and describes job elimination through attrition after automatic elevators spread. The commission's preface states that it did not necessarily endorse submitted statements.

Authorship, Project Leadership, Contributors, Funding, and Independence

Author

Rayan Semery-Palumbo is the primary author of this report. He led the project's research, policy development, analysis, writing, and production and integrated driver testimony, existing research, submitted proposals, financial modeling, and advisor feedback into the policy framework.

Project Co-Leads

The Workers First AI project was co-led by Andy Stern, Rayan Semery-Palumbo, and Tash Diallo. Their contributions differed.

Andy Stern advised project strategy, helped build financial and institutional support, recruited contributors and advisors, and connected the project with leaders in labor, government, economics, and technology. He is President Emeritus of the Service Employees International Union, which he led from 1996 to 2010; a Senior Fellow at the Economic Security Project; and the author of *Raising the Floor: How a Universal Basic Income Can Renew Our Economy and Rebuild the American Dream*.

Rayan Semery-Palumbo is a political economist and policy advocate, a Fellow at the Economic Security Project, and Director of Narrative Strategy at One Fair Wage, where he supports the Living Wage For All Coalition. He earned a DPhil in Policy and Economics from the University of Oxford, where he was a Rhodes Scholar. His commitment to just worker transitions is personal: his mother was displaced by AI.

Tash Diallo led the project's driver engagement and brought experience from organizing app-based drivers and working on automation's effects before this project. He is an Uber and Lyft driver, a veteran organizer, and the former National Organizing Director of the Independent Drivers Guild, where he helped lead campaigns that won in-app tipping and New York City's first minimum-pay standard for app-based drivers.

The Drivers

This report rests on the roughly 100 drivers who shared their experience through interviews, a survey, focus groups, and unrecorded conversations. Their testimony and judgment shaped the report’s questions, standards, and recommendations. We identify and photograph drivers only with their permission and use only the identifying details each driver approved. The six New York City focus-group drivers who consented to identification in this report are Shaun Beckles, Asad Iqbal, Dachuan Nie, Liakat Ali, Muneeb Rehman, and Jose Gomez. Other participating drivers remain unnamed unless they separately approved identification.

Contributors to the Policy Framework

We developed the policy framework in part from proposals submitted through the public call. The proposal credits in Part Three identify which ideas each submission informed. The proposal authors were: James Parrott (The New School); Devesh Kodnani and Emily Lemmerman (MIT); Jack Moriarty; Jacob Leibenluft (formerly in federal government); the Predistribution Initiative—Delilah Rothenberg, Raphaele Chappe, Juan Jardon, and Shannon Mullins; Graeme Nuttall OBE (Employee Ownership Association), with Danielle Soskin and Abby Gilbert of the Institute for the Future of Work.

The other proposal authors were Renan Magalhães (Kelso Institute Europe); Ariana Levinson (University of Louisville); Angelina Grigoryeva (University of Toronto); Kate Swain-Smith (Ownership Works); Minsun Ji, Erika Iacono, and Ryan Mazzola of the Rocky Mountain Employee Ownership Center; Laura Beltran Figueroa (Rutgers); Marco Lomuscio and Simona Ciappei (University of Trento and Politecnico di Milano); Catherine Lynch; and Tash Diallo.

Two additional proposals came from policy staff at a major ride-hail platform. The report identifies those contributors by role rather than by name. A proposal credit does not imply endorsement of the final policy framework.

The Advisory Panel

The advisory panel had twelve members from labor, finance, economics, philosophy, technology, and public administration. To preserve candor, the report draws on the panel's review without attributing individual comments. We name panel members only with their permission. Panel participation did not imply endorsement of the final policy framework.

Research, Consultation, and Project Support

The project benefited from sustained conversations with researchers, worker advocates, public officials, policy experts, industry participants, and project supporters. These conversations informed the questions we pursued and the risks we examined. We name individual participants only with their permission. Acknowledgment does not imply endorsement of the report's analysis or recommendations.

Funding and Independence

The project was supported by Omidyar Network, conducted in collaboration with the Economic Security Project, and sponsored by the Amalgamated Foundation. The author retained final responsibility for the report's research, analysis, and recommendations. No funder had authority to approve or change its findings or recommendations.

AI-Assisted Research and Editing

AI tools assisted with research organization, transcript search, source comparison, editing, and document production. Rayan Semery-Palumbo directed their use, checked the report's claims and citations against the underlying sources, made the substantive and editorial decisions, and accepts responsibility for the final report. AI tools are not authors.

Bibliography and Project Materials

The bibliography identifies the public works and unpublished project records cited in the notes. Company figures and plans are cited as company reports, not as independent findings. Web addresses and fast-moving public records were checked through August 5, 2026, and should be refreshed on the publication-lock date. Submitted proposals, interviews, focus groups, advisory materials, and the financial model are held in the project archive and are not public unless the project and any relevant rights holders authorize their release.

Academic Research, Data, and Surveys

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